Academic Paper

# Common Values between Traditional Chinese Virtues and Islamic Cultural Virtues: A Cross-Cultural Communication Perspective

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| **Course** | Chinese Culture and Cross-Cultural Communication (II) |
| **Paper Topic** | A Study on the Commonalities Between Traditional Chinese Virtues and Islamic Cultural Virtues and Their Application in Transnational Interpersonal Cross-Cultural Communication |
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| **Date** | 2026/07/04 |

## Abstract

In the modern world, cross-cultural communication has become an essential ability for students, teachers, workers, travelers, and people involved in international cooperation. Communication between cultures is not only a matter of language translation; it is also a process of understanding moral values, social customs, religious beliefs, and ways of thinking. Traditional Chinese culture and Islamic culture developed in different historical, philosophical, and religious environments, but they share many important moral values. Both cultures emphasize respect for parents and elders, honesty, kindness, modesty, responsibility, justice, and social harmony. These shared values can provide a strong foundation for better communication between Chinese people and people from Islamic cultural backgrounds. This paper compares traditional Chinese virtues and Islamic cultural virtues from a cross-cultural communication perspective. It first explains the moral foundations of Chinese and Islamic cultures, then analyzes common values such as filial piety, honesty, benevolence, modesty, justice, and social responsibility. Finally, it discusses how these shared virtues can be applied in daily interpersonal communication, especially in university life and international student communities in China. The paper argues that cultural differences should not only be seen as barriers. When people understand the shared moral foundations behind different cultures, differences can become opportunities for learning, respect, and friendship.


**Keywords:** Chinese virtues; Islamic culture; cross-cultural communication; moral values; interpersonal communication; filial piety; honesty; harmony

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## 1. Introduction

Cross-cultural communication has become one of the most important skills in contemporary society. Because of globalization, international education, economic cooperation, tourism, migration, and digital communication, people from different cultural backgrounds meet each other more frequently than in the past. A Chinese student may study with classmates from the Middle East, South Asia, Africa, or Central Asia. A Muslim international student may live in a Chinese university dormitory, communicate with Chinese teachers, shop in Chinese markets, use Chinese public transportation, and participate in Chinese social life. In these situations, communication is not limited to words. It also includes values, manners, customs, expectations, and attitudes.

Many misunderstandings in cross-cultural communication happen not because people are intentionally disrespectful, but because they interpret behavior through their own cultural background. For example, one person may think direct speech is honest, while another person may think it is impolite. One person may believe refusing directly is normal, while another person may prefer indirect refusal to protect harmony. One student may ask many questions about religious practices out of curiosity, while another student may feel uncomfortable if those questions are not asked respectfully. These examples show that cross-cultural communication requires more than vocabulary and grammar. It requires cultural awareness, empathy, patience, and moral understanding.

Traditional Chinese culture is one of the oldest cultural traditions in the world. It has been shaped by Confucianism, Taoism, Buddhism, historical family systems, social customs, and long experience of community life. Confucian thought especially influenced Chinese moral education and interpersonal relationships. Concepts such as **ren** (benevolence), **li** (ritual propriety or proper conduct), **xiao** (filial piety), **xin** (trustworthiness), and **he** (harmony) have played important roles in shaping Chinese communication behavior. The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy explains that Confucius is strongly associated with ritual, virtue cultivation, family relations, and social ethics; these areas are directly relevant to understanding traditional Chinese moral culture.

Islamic culture also has a rich moral tradition. Although Muslim societies are diverse and include many languages, nationalities, and local customs, Islamic teachings generally

emphasize faith, honesty, justice, mercy, modesty, respect for parents, charity, patience, and responsibility. In Islamic culture, morality is not separated from daily life. A person's behavior toward parents, neighbors, classmates, teachers, friends, strangers, and society is considered an important part of good character. The Qur'an repeatedly emphasizes ethical conduct, including kindness to parents, justice, charity, and speaking truthfully. For example, Qur'an 17:23 teaches kindness and respectful speech toward parents, while Qur'an 4:135 emphasizes standing firmly for justice even when it concerns oneself or close relatives.

At first glance, traditional Chinese culture and Islamic culture may seem very different. Chinese traditional virtues are often expressed through philosophy, family ethics, social roles, and rituals. Islamic virtues are strongly connected with religious belief and divine command. Chinese culture developed mainly in East Asia, while Islamic culture spread across the Middle East, North Africa, South Asia, Central Asia, Southeast Asia, and many other regions. However, when we look deeper, we can find many common moral concerns. Both cultures value family. Both respect parents and elders. Both praise honesty and condemn deception. Both encourage kindness to others. Both teach modesty and warn against arrogance. Both believe that individual behavior affects social harmony.

These common values are very important for cross-cultural communication. When Chinese people and people from Islamic cultural backgrounds interact, they may face differences in food, clothing, religious practice, greetings, social distance, humor, and communication style. However, shared moral values can reduce cultural distance. A Chinese student may not fully understand Islamic prayer or halal food at first, but if he understands the values of respect, modesty, and discipline behind them, he can communicate more respectfully. A Muslim student may not fully understand Chinese indirect communication or the importance of face, but if he understands the Chinese value of harmony, he can respond with more patience.

This paper focuses on the commonalities between traditional Chinese virtues and Islamic cultural virtues and their application in transnational interpersonal cross-cultural communication. The purpose is not to claim that Chinese culture and Islamic culture are identical. They are clearly different in many ways. Instead, the purpose is to show that different cultures can share similar moral foundations while expressing them differently. Understanding both similarity and difference can help people communicate more effectively and respectfully.

The paper is organized into several parts. First, it explains the moral foundations of traditional Chinese virtues and Islamic cultural virtues. Second, it compares major shared values, including respect for parents and elders, honesty, benevolence, modesty, justice, and social responsibility. Third, it analyzes how these values can improve daily cross-cultural communication. Finally, it concludes that shared virtues can become a bridge between cultures and a practical tool for building mutual respect among international students.

## 2. Moral Foundations of Traditional Chinese Virtues

Traditional Chinese virtues are deeply connected with the idea of moral self-cultivation. In Chinese thought, a good person is not only someone who obeys laws or follows external rules. A good person is someone who continuously improves his or her inner character and expresses this moral quality through behavior. Moral cultivation begins with the individual, but it does not end with the individual. It extends to family relationships, social responsibilities, and the stability of society.

Confucianism is one of the most influential traditions in Chinese moral culture. Confucian thought emphasizes that human beings live within relationships. A person is always connected with parents, teachers, friends, classmates, rulers, neighbors, and society. Therefore, morality is shown through proper behavior in these relationships. A person should respect parents, honor teachers, treat friends sincerely, behave politely, help others, and avoid actions that harm social harmony.

One of the most important Confucian values is **ren**, often translated as benevolence or humaneness. Ren means caring about others and treating people with kindness and empathy. It asks people to consider not only their own benefit but also the feelings and needs of others. In cross-cultural communication, ren is very important because it encourages people to understand others before judging them. If a Chinese student and an international student have different customs, the spirit of ren encourages both sides to ask, listen, and learn instead of quickly criticizing.

Another important value is **li**, which can be translated as ritual propriety, etiquette, or proper conduct. Li does not only refer to formal ceremonies. It also includes daily manners, politeness, appropriate speech, respect for social roles, and proper behavior in different

situations. In Chinese communication, li can appear in the way people greet teachers, speak to elders, offer gifts, refuse requests, or show respect in public. Li helps create order and reduces unnecessary conflict.

The virtue of **xiao**, or filial piety, is also central in Chinese culture. Xiao means respect, care, gratitude, and responsibility toward parents and elders. In Chinese society, the family is often considered the first school of moral education. A child learns respect, patience, gratitude, and responsibility through family life. A person who respects parents is expected to show responsibility in other social relationships as well. Therefore, filial piety is not only a private family value; it is also connected with social morality.

Trustworthiness, or **xin**, is another key virtue. A person with xin keeps promises, speaks sincerely, and acts reliably. Trust is very important in Chinese interpersonal relationships because many relationships are built gradually over time. People often judge a person not only by words but also by consistent behavior. If someone repeatedly keeps promises, arrives on time, and acts honestly, others will trust him more.

Harmony, or **he**, is also a major value in Chinese culture. Harmony does not mean that everyone must think the same way. It means that differences should be managed peacefully and respectfully. In communication, harmony may appear through patience, indirect expression, avoiding public embarrassment, and considering the feelings of others. For international students, understanding harmony is very important because Chinese communication may sometimes be less direct than communication styles in other cultures.

These traditional Chinese virtues show that Chinese culture places great importance on moral character, family responsibility, social order, and peaceful relationships. The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy describes Confucian thought as strongly concerned with ritual, virtues, character formation, and the relationship between family and society; this supports the idea that Chinese moral culture is deeply relational.

## 3. Moral Foundations of Islamic Cultural Virtues

Islamic cultural virtues are based on the close relationship between faith, morality, and daily behavior. In Islam, good character is not separate from religious life. A person's belief should be reflected in speech, actions, social relationships, and treatment of others. Islamic

morality includes worship, but it also includes honesty, justice, kindness, patience, modesty, generosity, and responsibility.

One of the most important Islamic virtues is respect for parents. The Qur'an gives parents a very high status and commands kindness toward them. Qur'an 17:23 teaches that people should treat parents with kindness and speak to them respectfully, especially when they reach old age. This value is very close to the Chinese idea of filial piety because both traditions view respect for parents as a foundation of moral life.

Honesty is another major Islamic virtue. A Muslim is expected to speak truthfully, keep promises, and avoid cheating or deception. Qur'an 33:70 tells believers to be mindful of God and "say what is right," which reflects the importance of truthful and responsible speech. In communication, honesty builds trust. Without honesty, relationships become weak, cooperation becomes difficult, and social confidence disappears.

Justice is also central to Islamic ethics. Qur'an 4:135 commands believers to stand firmly for justice even if it is against themselves, their parents, or close relatives. This is a strong moral principle because it shows that justice should not depend on personal interest, family pressure, wealth, or social status. In cross-cultural communication, justice means treating people fairly regardless of nationality, religion, language, or race.

Kindness and mercy are also important in Islamic culture. Qur'an 16:90 mentions justice, good conduct, and generosity to relatives, while forbidding oppression and bad conduct. This shows that Islamic morality is not only about avoiding wrong actions but also about actively doing good. Helping others, speaking gently, forgiving mistakes, and caring for people in need are important expressions of good character.

Charity and social responsibility are also emphasized. Qur'an 2:177 describes righteousness as including belief, charity to relatives, orphans, the needy, travelers, and those who ask for help, as well as keeping promises and being patient in hardship. This verse shows that righteousness in Islamic culture is practical. It is not only a private feeling; it must appear in actions that benefit society.

Another important Islamic value is respect for human diversity. Qur'an 49:13 states that human beings were made into peoples and tribes so that they may know one another. This idea

is very meaningful for cross-cultural communication because it suggests that cultural diversity should lead to knowledge, not hatred. People from different backgrounds should communicate, learn, and respect one another.

Therefore, Islamic cultural virtues provide a strong moral foundation for interpersonal communication. They encourage people to be honest, just, kind, modest, respectful, and responsible. These values are especially useful in multicultural environments such as Chinese universities, where students from different countries live and study together.

## 4. Common Value One: Respect for Parents and Elders

One of the clearest commonalities between traditional Chinese virtues and Islamic cultural virtues is respect for parents and elders. In both cultures, the family is considered the first place where moral education begins. Children learn language, behavior, respect, responsibility, and emotional connection from family life. Therefore, respect for parents is not only a personal feeling; it is also a moral duty.

In traditional Chinese culture, filial piety is one of the most important virtues. A child should respect parents, care for them, listen to their advice, and remember their sacrifices. This value has shaped Chinese family life for centuries. Even in modern China, many young people continue to feel strong responsibility toward their parents. They may consider their parents' opinions when choosing a university, career, marriage partner, or place to live. Although modern society has changed many family patterns, filial piety still influences Chinese ideas of responsibility and gratitude.

In Islamic culture, respect for parents is also extremely important. Children are taught to treat parents with kindness, patience, and gratitude. The Qur'an emphasizes gentle speech toward parents, especially when they become old and need care. This is similar to Chinese filial piety because both cultures connect family respect with moral character. A person who treats parents badly may be considered morally weak even if he is successful in education or business.

This shared value can create a strong bridge in cross-cultural communication. For example, when a Muslim international student studies in China, he may notice that many Chinese classmates contact their parents regularly, follow family advice, and feel responsible for family expectations. Instead of seeing this as pressure only, he can understand it as an expression of

filial responsibility. Similarly, Chinese students may understand that Muslim students' respect for parents is not only cultural but also religious and moral.

Respect for elders also affects communication style. In both Chinese and Islamic cultures, people are often expected to speak politely to older people, avoid rude interruption, and show patience. In a classroom, this can appear in the way students address teachers. In daily life, it may appear when young people give seats to older people, use polite language, or avoid embarrassing elders in public.

However, the expression of this value may differ. Chinese filial piety is strongly connected with Confucian family hierarchy and social roles. Islamic respect for parents is connected with obedience to God, gratitude, and moral responsibility. Chinese culture may emphasize family harmony and collective decision-making, while Islamic culture may emphasize kindness, duty, and accountability before God. These differences should be recognized, but they do not remove the shared foundation.

In cross-cultural communication, family values are often a good topic for building friendship. Students from different countries can talk about how they show respect to parents, how families support education, and how young people balance personal goals with family expectations. These conversations help people discover common human experiences. When people realize that another culture also respects family, they may feel closer and more willing to communicate.

## 5. Common Value Two: Honesty and Trustworthiness

Another important shared value is honesty. Communication depends on trust. A person may speak fluent Chinese, Arabic, English, Urdu, or any other language, but if people do not trust his words, communication will not succeed. Both traditional Chinese culture and Islamic culture consider honesty a necessary quality for good relationships and social stability.

In Chinese culture, honesty is closely connected with **xin**, meaning trustworthiness or sincerity. A trustworthy person keeps promises, speaks carefully, and does not deceive others. In traditional Chinese moral thought, trust is important because human relationships develop over time. Family, friendship, business, education, and public life all require trust. If a person often breaks promises, others will not feel safe cooperating with him.

In Islamic culture, honesty is also a core virtue. A person should speak the truth, keep promises, and avoid cheating. Truthfulness is important in family life, trade, study, friendship, and public responsibility. Qur'an 33:70 emphasizes speaking what is right, while Qur'an 2:177 connects righteousness with keeping promises. These values show that honesty is not only a personal habit but a moral duty.

The similarity between Chinese xin and Islamic honesty can improve cooperation between Chinese people and Muslim international students. For example, in group assignments, all students need to trust one another. If one student promises to finish a section of the project, he should complete it on time. If he cannot finish it, he should explain honestly instead of disappearing or giving excuses. When students act honestly, teamwork becomes easier and friendship becomes stronger.

Honesty is also important when misunderstandings happen. In cross-cultural communication, mistakes are normal. A person may use the wrong word, misunderstand a custom, or ask an uncomfortable question. If people are honest and respectful, they can explain the problem and correct it. But if people hide their feelings or speak badly behind each other, misunderstanding becomes deeper.

At the same time, honesty must be expressed wisely. Some cultures prefer direct communication, while others prefer indirect communication. In Chinese communication, people may avoid saying “no” directly because they want to protect harmony and save face. This does not always mean dishonesty. It may be a polite way to avoid embarrassing another person. In some Islamic cultural contexts, people may prefer more direct speech when discussing moral issues. Because of this difference, a Muslim student may sometimes think a Chinese person is unclear, while a Chinese person may think the Muslim student is too direct.

Therefore, honesty in cross-cultural communication should be combined with cultural sensitivity. A good communicator should be sincere but not rude, clear but not aggressive, and truthful but not humiliating. When honesty is joined with respect, it becomes a bridge of trust between cultures.

## 6. Common Value Three: Benevolence, Mercy, and Kindness

Kindness is another major common value between Chinese traditional culture and Islamic culture. In Chinese culture, the concept of **ren** is one of the highest moral ideals. Ren means benevolence, humaneness, and care for others. It encourages people to think about the feelings and needs of other people. A person with ren does not act selfishly or treat others coldly. He tries to behave with empathy and moral concern.

In Islamic culture, mercy and kindness are also strongly emphasized. Qur'an 16:90 mentions justice, good conduct, and giving to relatives, while forbidding oppression and bad behavior. Kindness in Islamic culture includes helping the poor, respecting neighbors, caring for family members, speaking gently, forgiving mistakes, and treating people fairly. It is not limited to Muslims only; it is a general moral attitude toward human beings.

This shared value is very useful in cross-cultural communication. Language mistakes are common when students study abroad. An international student in China may not speak Chinese perfectly. A Chinese student may not speak English or Arabic fluently. If people are impatient, they may laugh, judge, or avoid communication. But if they practice kindness, they will listen patiently and help each other express meaning. This simple kindness can reduce stress and make communication more successful.

Kindness also helps people avoid stereotypes. Sometimes people judge another culture based on limited information. A Chinese student may not know much about Islamic customs such as halal food, prayer, fasting, or modest dress. A Muslim student may not understand some Chinese customs such as indirect refusal, gift-giving, or the importance of group harmony. If both sides communicate with kindness, questions can become learning opportunities. But if questions are asked rudely or answered angrily, communication may become negative.

In university life, kindness can appear in simple actions. A Chinese classmate may help an international student understand homework instructions. An international student may explain his culture patiently when classmates ask questions. A teacher may speak slowly when students have language difficulties. Dormitory roommates may respect each other’s sleeping habits, food rules, and personal space. These small actions may seem ordinary, but they are powerful in building cross-cultural friendship.

Kindness also creates emotional safety. Many international students feel lonely when they first arrive in a new country. They may miss their families, struggle with language, or feel confused about university procedures. When Chinese classmates or teachers show kindness, international students feel welcomed. At the same time, when international students show respect and kindness toward Chinese culture, local students feel appreciated.

Therefore, benevolence in Chinese culture and mercy in Islamic culture can be understood as two different expressions of a similar moral principle: people should care for one another. This principle is essential for successful cross-cultural communication because it moves people away from suspicion and toward empathy.

## 7. Common Value Four: Modesty and Humility

Modesty is another important virtue shared by traditional Chinese culture and Islamic culture. In Chinese culture, modesty is often seen as a sign of good education and self-cultivation. People are encouraged not to boast, not to act arrogantly, and not to make others lose face. Even when someone is talented or successful, he may respond to praise with humble words. This does not always mean he lacks confidence. It often means he wants to show politeness and avoid appearing arrogant.

In Islamic culture, humility is also highly valued. A person should not look down on others because of wealth, nationality, knowledge, race, or social position. Qur'an 49:13 teaches that human beings were created as different peoples and tribes so that they may know one another, and that nobility is connected with righteousness rather than race or group identity. This idea supports humility because it reminds people that no nationality or culture should claim automatic superiority over others.

Modesty is important in cross-cultural communication because arrogance can easily destroy relationships. When people believe their culture is the only correct one, they may judge other customs too quickly. For example, someone may think another culture’s food, clothing, greeting style, or religious practice is strange simply because it is different. This attitude creates distance. Humility helps people pause before judging. It allows them to ask, “What does this practice mean in that culture?”

Modesty also helps people listen. Many communication problems happen because people only want to explain their own culture and do not want to understand others. A modest person recognizes that he does not know everything. He is willing to learn from classmates, teachers, neighbors, and friends. In a multicultural classroom, this attitude is very important. Students should not treat cultural discussion as a competition about whose culture is better. Instead, they should treat it as an opportunity to learn.

In Chinese communication, modesty may appear through indirect self-presentation. A Chinese student may avoid praising himself strongly, even if he has achieved something impressive. In Islamic communication, modesty may appear through humility before God, polite behavior, and self-control in speech and appearance. These expressions are different, but both point toward the same moral idea: a person should control pride and treat others respectfully.

For international students, modesty is especially useful. A student who enters a new culture with arrogance will face many problems. He may complain constantly, reject local customs, or misunderstand people's intentions. But a modest student will learn faster. He will ask questions politely, accept correction, and try to understand the local environment. At the same time, local students should also be modest. They should not assume that international students are wrong simply because they behave differently.

Therefore, modesty and humility are practical tools for cross-cultural communication. They help people avoid cultural superiority, listen carefully, and treat differences with respect.

## 8. Common Value Five: Justice and Fair Treatment

Justice is another important value in both Islamic and Chinese moral traditions. Justice means treating people fairly, giving people their rights, and avoiding oppression or unfair advantage. In interpersonal communication, justice means that people should not judge others unfairly because of nationality, religion, language ability, skin color, or cultural background.

In Islamic culture, justice is strongly emphasized. Qur'an 4:135 commands believers to stand firmly for justice even if it is against themselves, parents, or relatives. This is a powerful moral teaching because it shows that justice should be stronger than personal interest or group

loyalty. Qur'an 16:90 also mentions justice and good conduct together, showing that justice is part of a healthy moral society.

Traditional Chinese culture also values fairness and moral responsibility. Confucian thought includes the idea of **yi**, often translated as righteousness or appropriateness. Yi refers to doing what is morally right rather than simply seeking personal profit. A person with yi does not abandon moral principles for selfish gain. In Chinese social ethics, a good person should act responsibly toward family, friends, community, and society.

Justice is very important in cross-cultural settings because cultural minorities or international students may sometimes feel misunderstood. For example, if an international student speaks Chinese poorly, others should not assume he is unintelligent. If a Muslim student has halal food requirements, others should not laugh or pressure him to eat forbidden food. If a Chinese student follows local customs that foreign students do not understand, international students should not quickly judge those customs as wrong. Fair treatment requires people to understand the situation before making judgments.

Justice also matters in classroom communication. Teachers should treat students from different countries fairly. Students should have equal chances to ask questions, participate in discussion, and receive help. Group members should divide work fairly and respect each person’s contribution. If one student is quiet because of language difficulty, others should not ignore him. Instead, they should create space for participation.

Fair treatment also includes avoiding stereotypes. It is unfair to judge all Chinese people by one person’s behavior, and it is unfair to judge all Muslims by one country or one news story. Every culture contains diversity. Chinese people differ by region, age, education, personality, and family background. Muslims also differ by country, language, school of thought, culture, and personal experience. Justice in communication means recognizing people as individuals, not only as representatives of a group.

Therefore, justice and fair treatment are necessary for real cross-cultural respect. Without justice, communication becomes unequal. With justice, people feel respected and safe enough to communicate honestly.

## 9. Common Value Six: Social Responsibility and Harmony

Both traditional Chinese culture and Islamic culture connect personal morality with social responsibility. In other words, being a good person is not only about private behavior. It is also about contributing to family, community, and society.

In Chinese culture, the value of harmony is very important. Harmony means peaceful and balanced relationships. It does not mean that all people must be the same or that disagreement is forbidden. Rather, harmony means that people should manage differences respectfully and avoid unnecessary conflict. In Chinese communication, this may appear through indirect language, careful emotional control, and concern for group atmosphere.

Islamic culture also emphasizes responsibility toward society. Qur'an 2:177 connects righteousness with charity, keeping promises, and patience in hardship. This shows that moral life includes social care. People should help relatives, orphans, the needy, travelers, and those in difficulty. Social responsibility is not only a government duty; it is also a personal moral responsibility.

In cross-cultural communication, social responsibility means that every person should contribute to a respectful environment. In a university dormitory, this means keeping shared spaces clean, respecting quiet hours, and understanding roommates' habits. In a classroom, it means participating responsibly, helping classmates, and avoiding behavior that creates tension. In public life, it means respecting local laws, customs, and social expectations.

Harmony is especially important when people from different cultures live together. Differences in food smell, sleeping time, religious practice, communication style, and personal space can create conflict. If students only think about themselves, small problems may become serious. But if they think about group harmony and social responsibility, they can solve problems through discussion and compromise.

For example, a Muslim student may need to wake up early for prayer or avoid certain foods. A Chinese roommate may need quiet time for study or sleep. Both sides should communicate respectfully. The Muslim student can explain his needs politely, and the Chinese roommate can respond with understanding. At the same time, the Muslim student should also

consider the roommate's comfort. This balance between personal needs and social responsibility reflects both Chinese harmony and Islamic moral responsibility.

Social responsibility also includes representing one's culture positively. International students often become cultural ambassadors, whether they want to or not. Their behavior may influence how local people understand their country or religion. Therefore, acting with honesty, kindness, and respect can improve the image of one's culture. Similarly, Chinese students who treat international students respectfully help foreigners develop a positive understanding of China.

Thus, harmony and social responsibility are not abstract ideas. They are practical principles for daily life. They help people live together peacefully despite differences.

## 10. Application in Transnational Interpersonal Communication

The shared virtues discussed above can be applied directly in transnational interpersonal communication. They are especially useful in universities, where students from different countries interact every day. A university is not only a place for academic learning. It is also a place where young people learn how to live with cultural diversity.

First, shared virtues help build trust. Trust is the foundation of friendship and cooperation. Students can build trust by keeping promises, being honest, arriving on time, respecting agreements, and speaking politely. These behaviors are valued in both Chinese and Islamic cultures. When people see that others are reliable, they feel more comfortable communicating with them.

Second, shared virtues help reduce misunderstanding. Many cultural misunderstandings happen because people do not know the reason behind another person's behavior. For example, a Chinese student may wonder why a Muslim classmate does not eat certain food. A Muslim student may wonder why a Chinese classmate refuses an invitation indirectly instead of saying "no" clearly. If both sides use kindness and patience, they can ask and explain respectfully. Shared values such as respect and benevolence make this process easier.

Third, shared virtues help manage conflict. Conflict is natural in cross-cultural communication. Different people may have different habits, schedules, emotional expressions, and expectations. The goal is not to avoid all conflict, but to handle conflict wisely. Honesty

helps people explain the problem. Modesty helps them admit mistakes. Kindness helps them avoid hurting each other. Justice helps them find a fair solution. Harmony helps them protect the relationship.

Fourth, shared virtues support cultural adaptation. International students in China need to adapt to a new language, educational system, food environment, social rules, and daily lifestyle. Understanding Chinese values such as harmony, respect for teachers, face-saving, and group responsibility can help them adapt more easily. At the same time, Chinese students and teachers who understand Islamic values such as halal food, prayer, modesty, and family responsibility can communicate more respectfully with Muslim students.

Fifth, shared virtues can improve classroom discussion. Cross-cultural communication courses often ask students to compare cultures. These discussions can be sensitive because culture is connected with identity. If students speak carelessly, others may feel offended. But if students use modesty and respect, discussion becomes productive. They can explain differences without attacking other cultures.

Sixth, shared virtues can create friendship beyond nationality. Many people first identify others by country, language, or religion. However, when they discover shared values, they begin to see each other as human beings with similar moral concerns. A Chinese student and a Muslim student may come from different backgrounds, but both may love their parents, value honesty, care about friendship, and want peaceful relationships. This discovery can create emotional closeness.

Finally, shared virtues can support the larger goal of intercultural understanding. Qur'an 49:13 states that peoples and tribes exist so that they may know one another. This idea fits the purpose of cross-cultural communication. Cultural diversity should not lead to fear or disrespect. It should lead to knowledge, cooperation, and mutual growth.

## 11. Differences That Should Also Be Respected

Although this paper focuses on common values, it is important not to ignore differences. Cross-cultural communication becomes stronger when people understand both similarities and differences. If we only say that Chinese culture and Islamic culture are similar, we may

oversimplify them. Real respect means recognizing differences without turning them into barriers.

One difference is the foundation of morality. Traditional Chinese virtues are often explained through philosophy, family ethics, social harmony, and human relationships. Islamic virtues are based on religious belief, divine command, and accountability before God. This means that similar values may have different meanings. For example, respect for parents in Chinese culture may be explained through filial piety and family order, while respect for parents in Islamic culture is explained as a religious and moral duty.

Another difference is communication style. Chinese communication often values indirectness, face-saving, and harmony. In many Islamic cultural contexts, people may be more direct, especially when discussing moral truth, religious identity, or right and wrong. These differences can create misunderstanding. Direct speech may be understood as rude by one side, while indirect speech may be understood as unclear by another side.

Food culture is another difference. Many Muslims follow halal dietary rules and avoid pork and alcohol. In China, food culture is very diverse, and pork is common in many regions. Without cultural awareness, food situations can become uncomfortable. However, with respect and communication, these differences can be managed easily. Chinese friends can ask about halal requirements, and Muslim students can explain them politely.

Religious practice is also a difference. Muslim students may pray, fast during Ramadan, or follow modest dress practices. Some Chinese classmates may not be familiar with these practices. They may ask questions out of curiosity. The important thing is that questions should be asked respectfully, and answers should be given patiently. In this way, religious difference can become a chance for learning.

There may also be differences in family expectations, gender interaction, humor, privacy, and social habits. These differences should not be ignored. Shared virtues do not remove difference; rather, they give people the moral tools to handle difference. Respect helps people accept difference. Honesty helps people explain difference. Kindness helps people avoid hurting each other. Modesty helps people learn. Justice helps people treat each other fairly.

Therefore, the best approach to cross-cultural communication is balanced. People should recognize common values but also respect different expressions of those values. This balanced view avoids two mistakes: thinking that all cultures are completely the same, and thinking that all cultures are completely separate. In reality, cultures are different, but human beings often share similar moral hopes.

## 12. Conclusion

Traditional Chinese virtues and Islamic cultural virtues come from different historical and cultural backgrounds, but they share many important moral values. Both cultures emphasize respect for parents and elders, honesty, kindness, modesty, justice, responsibility, and social harmony. These shared virtues provide a strong foundation for cross-cultural communication between Chinese people and people from Islamic cultural backgrounds.

Respect for parents and elders creates a common emotional and moral bridge. Honesty and trustworthiness support cooperation and friendship. Benevolence, mercy, and kindness reduce misunderstanding and help people communicate with patience. Modesty and humility prevent cultural arrogance and encourage learning. Justice and fair treatment protect people from stereotypes and discrimination. Social responsibility and harmony help people live together peacefully in multicultural environments.

At the same time, similarities should not make us ignore differences. Chinese culture and Islamic culture express moral values in different ways. Chinese virtues are often connected with Confucian philosophy, family roles, and social harmony. Islamic virtues are connected with faith, divine command, and religious duty. Communication styles, food rules, religious practices, and social habits may also differ. These differences should be respected rather than judged negatively.

The most important lesson is that cross-cultural communication is not only about speaking another language. It is about understanding the values behind behavior. When people understand shared moral values, they can communicate with more empathy and confidence. When they respect differences, they can avoid conflict and build deeper relationships.

For international students in China, these shared virtues are especially practical. They can help students adapt to Chinese society, build friendships with Chinese classmates, communicate

better with teachers, and represent their own cultures positively. They can also help Chinese students understand Muslim classmates more respectfully. In this way, shared virtues become not only academic concepts but also practical tools for daily life.

In conclusion, traditional Chinese virtues and Islamic cultural virtues show that different civilizations can meet through morality. Although cultures have different histories and expressions, they can still share values that support human dignity, family responsibility, friendship, justice, and peace. Cross-cultural communication becomes more successful when people do not only look at external differences, but also discover the shared moral heart behind different traditions.

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